
The Negotiation Room

Scripts Pack

Forty-one scripts for the moments you freeze.

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The professionals you cannot afford, made free and plain.

How to use this

The free tool builds your plan. This is what you say when the plan meets a real person.

Every script here is written to be said out loud. They are short on purpose. A long sentence in a negotiation is a sentence with a place to interrupt you.

Do not read this like a book. Find the situation you are walking into, read those three or four lines, say them aloud twice, and close the file. Ten minutes of that beats an hour of reading about negotiation.

Where a script sounds slightly stiff, that is deliberate. Stiff and clear beats smooth and vague. You are not trying to sound like a negotiator. You are trying to be understood and hard to move.

The four rules that do most of the work

Everything else in this pack is an application of these four.

1. Say the number, then stop talking

The most common mistake is making the ask and then continuing to talk. The silence after a number feels far longer to the person who said it than to the person who heard it. Filling it is how people negotiate themselves down before the other side has said a word.

Make the ask. Close your mouth. Count to ten in your head if you need something to do with it.

2. Never negotiate against yourself

You do not lower your number until they have countered. Not after a pause, not after a frown, not after "that is going to be difficult." None of those are counters. A counter has a number in it.

3. Put the problem on their side

"That does not work for me" is a wall. "What would it take to get there?" is a door, and walking through it is their job. The second one gets answers, and the answers tell you where the real flexibility is hiding.

4. Be easy to say yes to and hard to move

Warm tone, firm number. People concede to people they like and dig in against people who fight them. Both halves matter: warm and movable gets you nothing, cold and firm gets you a reputation.

What is in here

Section	Scripts	Use it when
Salary and raises	14	A new offer, a raise conversation, a promotion with no money attached
Rent	7	Renewal, a mid-lease increase, signing something new
Bills and subscriptions	6	Retention lines, a price rise, a competitor quote in hand
The hard moments	9	It went sideways and you need a line right now
In writing	5	The whole thing is happening over email

Plus a ten-minute prep checklist and four rehearsal prompts that go further than the free tool's.

This is general coaching, not legal, financial, or career advice. Not every script fits every situation, and some of them carry real risk in the wrong context. You know your circumstances and your relationships. Use your judgment, and where the stakes are high enough to need a professional, get one.

Salary and raises

Fourteen scripts. The first five cover a new offer, the next five a raise where you already work, and the last four the situations that come up in both.

A new offer

1. They ask your expectations before you have a number

This is the question that costs people the most money, because answering it first sets the ceiling and you are guessing in the dark.

"I would rather hear the range you have budgeted for the role. You know what it is worth to you better than I can guess from outside."

If they push a second time, give a range whose **bottom** is a number you would be happy with, never a range whose top is your target. They will hear the bottom.

"If it helps, I am looking in the range of [target] to [target plus fifteen percent]."

2. They name a number and it is lower than you wanted

Do not accept, do not reject, and do not counter yet. Say almost nothing and let it sit.

"Thank you for putting a number on it. Can I take a day with that?"

A day is almost always granted, and it converts a live decision you would make under pressure into a considered one you make at a desk.

3. The counter

This is the whole game in four sentences. Number, reason, silence.

"I am glad we are close. Based on [the specific evidence], I was expecting [your number]. Can we get there?"

Then stop. Do not add "but I am flexible." Do not add "if that is not possible I understand." Both of those hand the number back.

4. They say the offer is final

Often true about base pay and almost never true about everything.

"I understand the base is fixed. Are the other pieces fixed too? A signing amount, the review date, the title, the start date, or time off would all matter to me."

A **review date** is the most underrated ask on that list. Moving a review from twelve months to six is a raise with a delay, and it usually costs the manager nothing today.

5. Accepting properly

Get it in writing before you resign from anything.

"That works. Could you send the written offer with those terms, and I will sign it today?"

A raise where you already work

6. Booking the conversation

Never ambush a manager with this, and never let it ride in as one item on a status meeting.

"Could we book twenty minutes this week or next? I would like to talk about my compensation. I want to give you notice so it is not a surprise."

Telling them the topic in advance is a favor to you, not just to them. A manager blindsided says no by reflex; a manager who has had three days can arrive with the answer already half-built.

7. The opening

"I have been here [time] and my scope has changed in a few specific ways: [two or three]. I have looked at what the role pays elsewhere and I would like to talk about moving my salary to [number]."

Two or three pieces of evidence, not seven. A long list reads as a case being argued, and an argued case invites a rebuttal. Three strong items land as a statement of fact.

8. They say there is no budget

"I understand this cycle is set. What I am asking for is where this goes next. What would it take, and when is the next point where it could actually change?"

Then get a date and a number out of the room. Without both, "no budget" becomes a permanent condition.

"So if I land [the specific thing], we revisit at [month] at [number]. Can I write that up and send it to you so we are both working from the same note?"

9. They say you are already at the top of the band

Bands are real. They are also not the only lever.

"If I am at the top of the band, then the conversation I should be having is about the next band. What does the case for that look like, and who else has to agree?"

This converts a closed question into an open one and gets you the name of the person who actually decides.

10. A promotion arrives with no money attached

"I am glad you think I am ready for it. Can we talk about the compensation that goes with it? I would rather settle that now than take on the scope first and discuss it later."

"I would rather settle that now" is the load-bearing sentence. Scope accepted is leverage spent.

Both situations

11. They ask what you currently earn

In several US states and cities it is illegal for them to ask. Whether or not it is where you are, you do not have to answer it.

"I would rather not anchor this on my last role. What matters is what this role is worth. What have you budgeted for it?"

If they insist and you judge that refusing costs you the process, give your **target**, framed as total compensation, not your current base.

12. They ask if you have another offer and you do not

Never invent one. An invented offer is one phone call from ending the conversation, and people do check.

"I am not running a process anywhere else. I am asking based on what the work is worth, not on a competing number."

Said plainly this is strong, not weak. It says your number has a reason behind it that does not evaporate when the other offer does.

13. Sweeteners worth asking for when cash is stuck

Ask for one or two, not a shopping list. A list reads as someone who will take anything.

- A **review at six months** with a number attached, not a vague revisit
- A **signing amount**, which often comes from a different budget than salary
- **Title**, which costs nothing today and compounds for the rest of your career
- **Time off**, or a fixed remote arrangement in writing
- A **training or conference budget**, the easiest yes on this list
- **Start date** moved back two weeks, which is real money if you are between roles

14. Closing, either way

"Can we make that work?"

Five words, a yes or no question, and then quiet. Most people spoil the close by softening it into "so, is there any chance we could maybe look at that?" That version is easy to say no to because it was never really a question.

Rent

Seven scripts. A landlord's economics are different from an employer's, and the difference is the whole leverage: **a vacant month costs them more than your increase earns them.** An apartment empty for one month at \$2,400 wipes out a \$200 increase for the entire next year. Most small landlords know this instinctively. Most tenants never say it.

15. The renewal ask, before they send a number

Timing matters more here than anywhere else in this pack. Ask **sixty to ninety days out**, before they have set the number, priced the unit, or listed it. After the letter arrives you are arguing them down from a position they have committed to.

"I am planning to stay another year. Before you set the renewal, I wanted to ask whether you would keep it at the current rate. I pay on time, I have not needed much, and I would rather commit now than either of us deal with a turnover."

16. The increase letter has already arrived

"I got the renewal notice. I want to stay, and [new number] is more than I can take on. I can commit today at [your number]. Would that work?"

"I can commit today" is the strongest phrase available to a tenant. You are offering certainty, which is the thing they actually want.

17. They will not move on the rate

Then trade for something other than the rate.

"If the rate is set, could we look at the term instead? I would sign for two years at that number if you can hold it flat for the second."

Other things that cost a landlord little and are worth real money to you: the parking space, a storage unit, a repair or replacement you have been waiting on, the pet fee, or the right to sublet.

18. Naming the vacancy math without being rude

Say it as arithmetic, never as a threat. The moment it sounds like a threat you have invited them to call it.

"I know one empty month costs more than the increase brings in over the year. I would rather neither of us end up there, which is why I am asking now instead of later."

19. You genuinely would move

"I would like to stay. At [their number] I would be looking at other places, and I would rather not spend my autumn doing that. At [your number] I sign today."

Only say this if it is true. If they call it and you stay anyway, you have told them your number means nothing, and next year's conversation is already lost.

20. Signing somewhere new

New leases have more give than renewals, because the unit is empty right now and every day of that is a loss.

"I am ready to sign and I can move [their earliest date]. Is there any flexibility on the rent for a longer lease, or on the move-in costs?"

Move-in costs are often easier for them to move than rent, because rent sets a number that shows up in their books every month and a waived fee does not.

21. Getting it in writing

"Could you send the amended terms in writing before I sign? I want to make sure we are both working from the same numbers."

A verbal agreement with a landlord is worth exactly as much as the memory of whoever you spoke to, and property managers change.

Bills and subscriptions

Six scripts. This is the easiest money in the pack and the least emotionally expensive, because the person on the phone is not your manager or your landlord. They are an employee with a retention target, and a discount they can apply without asking anyone.

The single most important move is getting to the right department. Front-line support usually cannot discount anything. The retention desk can, and it has a different script, different authority, and a number it is measured on.

22. Getting to the people who can actually help

On the phone tree, say **"cancel"**. Not billing, not support, not "speak to an agent". Cancel is the word that routes you to retention.

"I would like to cancel my service, please."

You are not obliged to actually cancel. You are obliged to be willing to, which is a different thing and the only thing that makes this work.

23. The opening, once you have retention

"I have been with you [time] and my bill has gone from [old] to [new]. I am seeing [competitor] at [their price]. I would rather not switch. Is there anything you can do?"

Then stop talking. This is the same silence rule as everywhere else, and it works particularly well on the phone, where dead air is uncomfortable for the person whose job it is to fill it.

24. The first offer is never the best offer

There is almost always a second tier, and it usually appears only if you decline the first.

"I appreciate that. It is still more than [competitor]. Is that the best available, or is there a better tier you can look at?"

"Is that the best available" is the exact phrase. It asks them to check rather than to decide, and checking is easier to say yes to.

25. They say the promotional rate has ended

"I understand the promotion ended. What promotions are running right now? I would like to be moved onto whichever one applies."

Existing customers are usually eligible for current promotions and are simply never moved onto them, because nothing in the system does it automatically and nobody is paid to.

26. They cannot go lower

Take the non-price concession instead. It is often worth more than the discount you were refused.

"If the rate is fixed, can you waive the [equipment, service, or delivery] fee instead? Or move me to the faster tier at this price?"

27. Locking it in

"Thank you. How long does that rate hold, and will it renew automatically or drop off?"

Write the expiry date in your calendar with a reminder two weeks before.

Almost every retention discount is time-boxed, and the entire saving is undone by forgetting. One calendar entry is the difference between a discount and a recurring discount.

The hard moments

Nine scripts. This is the section to read the night before. Everything above assumes things go roughly to plan. These are for when they do not, and they are the reason most people lose money they had already earned.

28. You already said a number, and it was too low

The most common disaster, and it is recoverable far more often than people believe. The move is to reopen on new information, not to contradict yourself.

"I want to correct something I said earlier. I gave you a number before I had looked properly at [the scope, the market, the full picture]. Having done that, the right number is [higher]. I would rather raise it now than sign something I am not comfortable with."

Do this **as early as possible** and only once. Reopening twice destroys your credibility, and after that no number you give means anything.

29. They go silent for a week

Silence is rarely rejection. It is usually an approval sitting in someone's inbox.

"Following up on this. Is there anything you need from me to move it along?"

Send it once. Then wait a week and send exactly one more. Three follow-ups in ten days reads as anxiety, and anxiety is a discount.

30. The exploding offer

"We need an answer by end of day" is almost always pressure rather than a real constraint.

"I want to give you a proper answer rather than a fast one. I can come back to you by [a specific, reasonable time]. Does that work?"

Naming your own deadline is what makes this work. "I need more time" invites negotiation about time. "I will come back Thursday morning" is a plan.

If it genuinely explodes over a two-day extension, you have learned something important about how they will treat you after you sign.

31. You have no walk-away and you know it

Real situations: you need the job, you cannot move, you cannot cancel the service. The instinct is to bluff. Do not. Bluffs get called and then you have nothing.

"I want to be straightforward. I am not playing you off against anyone. I am asking because I think the number should be [X], and I would like you to consider it."

Asked plainly, with no leverage and no pretence, this works more often than people expect, because it is disarming and because it is obviously true. What you lose is the ability to threaten. You keep the ability to ask, and most of the value was in the ask.

32. They get personal or irritated

Do not match it and do not apologize for asking.

"I am not trying to make this difficult. This matters to me, which is why I raised it. Should we pick it up another time?"

Offering to pause is not a retreat. It takes the heat out without conceding anything, and the conversation resumes with the ask still standing.

33. You are asked to justify yourself

The trap is over-explaining. Every extra reason is a new thing to attack.

"I have given you my reasoning. I am comfortable with the number."

Then stop. A number you keep defending starts to sound negotiable. A number you state once sounds like a fact.

34. They counter in the middle and you were not ready

Buy yourself the pause out loud. This is entirely normal and nobody thinks less of you for it.

"Let me think about that for a moment."

Then actually be quiet for a few seconds. Deciding in the silence is better than deciding while talking, and talking while deciding is how people accept things they did not mean to.

35. You get an emotional yes and want to lock it in

The riskiest moment in the whole process, because it feels finished and it is not.

"That is great, thank you. Could you put that in an email so I have it?"

Verbal agreements evaporate, budgets get revisited, and the person who said yes may not be the person who processes it. Ask warmly and ask immediately.

36. Deciding whether to accept, afterwards

Not a script, a test. Ask yourself one question:

If this exact deal is still the deal in twelve months, and nothing has improved, am I fine with that?

If yes, take it. If no, what you actually need is not a better number today but a written date when it changes, which is script 8.

In writing

Five templates. Negotiating over email is different, and mostly better for you: you get to draft, and nobody can use silence against you.

Three rules for written negotiation.

Keep it **short**. A long email invites a long reply picking at each point. Four sentences is plenty and reads as settled.

Put the **number in its own line**. Buried in a paragraph it gets skimmed past; alone it has to be answered.

Never send it the moment you write it. **Sleep on anything with a number in it**, or at minimum walk away for an hour. The version you send after a break is almost always better than the one you wrote hot.

37. The counter, by email

Subject: Re: Offer, [role]

Hi [name],

Thank you for this, and I am glad we are close. I would like to accept, and I am hoping we can get closer on base.

Based on [one specific piece of evidence], I was expecting **[your number]**.

If you can get there I am ready to sign this week. Is that something you can do?

[name]

38. The raise request, by email

Use this to book the conversation, not to have it. Compensation goes badly in writing when it is a debate and well in writing when it is a summary.

Subject: Twenty minutes about my compensation

Hi [name],

Could we find twenty minutes in the next week or two? I would like to talk through my compensation.

For context so you can come prepared: my scope has changed in a few ways since [date], specifically [two items], and I have looked at what the role pays elsewhere.

Happy to work around your calendar.

[name]

39. The written summary after a verbal yes

Send this the same day, every time. It is the single highest-value email in this pack.

Subject: Summary of what we agreed

Hi [name],

Thank you for the conversation. Writing down what I understood so we are working from the same note:

- [Term one, with the number]
- [Term two, with the date]

Let me know if I have any of that wrong. Otherwise I will take it as agreed.

[name]

"Let me know if I have any of that wrong" makes silence work **for** you. If they do not reply, the version in writing is the version that exists.

40. The follow-up on silence

Subject: Re: [original]

Hi [name],

Checking in on this. Is there anything you need from me to move it forward?

[name]

41. Declining without closing the door

Worth writing well. Roles reopen, landlords change their minds, and people move companies and remember how you handled it.

Hi [name],

Thank you for the offer, and for how straightforward you have been throughout. I am not going to take it, and I wanted to tell you quickly rather than leave you waiting.

I hope our paths cross again.

[name]

No reason is required. Giving one invites a rebuttal, and there is nothing left to negotiate.

The ten-minute prep

Do this the night before, not in the car. Writing it by hand is better than typing it, because the point is to have the numbers in your head rather than on a screen you will not open.

1. Write three numbers. Anchor, target, walk-away. The anchor sits above the target. The walk-away is the point where you genuinely stop, and if you cannot name it honestly, say so to yourself now rather than discovering it mid-sentence.

2. Write three pieces of evidence. Three, not seven. Specific, checkable, and about value delivered rather than effort spent. "I took over the [X] account and it grew forty percent" beats "I have worked really hard this year."

3. Write your opening sentence word for word. Only the opening. Once it is out of your mouth the conversation is live and a script stops helping, but the first sentence is the one people fumble.

4. Say it out loud twice. Out loud. Reading it silently does not rehearse the part that actually fails, which is your voice doing something unfamiliar under pressure.

5. Decide your one concession in advance. Know the single thing you will trade and what you want for it. Deciding this live is how people give away the thing they cared about most.

6. Pick your exit line. One sentence that ends the meeting without ending the negotiation: *"Let me think about it and come back to you."* Have it ready so you are never trapped into deciding.

Rehearsal prompts

The free tool gives you one prompt for a straightforward practice run. These four are for when you want it to be harder than the real thing, which is the only way rehearsal is worth the time.

Paste any of these into whichever AI assistant you use.

The difficult counterpart

You are the hiring manager for [role]. I am negotiating my offer. Play it realistically and make it hard: push back at least three times, use silence, say "that is above our band" at least once, and do not concede until I have made a genuine case. My situation: [context]. My target: [number]. Start with your first line and stay in character until I say stop.

The pressure test on your own case

Here is the case I plan to make for a raise: [paste it]. Do not coach me yet. First, attack it. Give me the five strongest objections a skeptical manager would raise, ranked by how much damage they do. Then, for each, tell me the shortest honest answer.

The what-if drill

I am negotiating [situation]. Run me through six curveballs, one at a time, waiting for my answer before the next: they lowball me, they ask what I currently earn, they go silent for a week, they give me a deadline of today, they get irritated, they say yes but only verbally. After each answer, tell me in one line what a stronger version would have been.

The afterwards review

Here is what happened in my negotiation: [what you said, what they said, what you agreed]. Tell me where I was strong, where I conceded too early, and what specifically I should say differently next time. Be blunt. I would rather hear it from you than lose the money again.

One last thing

Most of the money people leave on the table is not lost to a bad script. It is lost to not asking at all, or to asking and then filling the silence.

You now have forty-one things to say. The hard part was never the words.

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The free tool, always free: mpacarroll.github.io/ai-negotiation-coach/tool/